יַעֲלַת־חֵן, רַחֲמִי לְבָב

יַעֲלַת חֵן, רַחֲמִי לְבָב שֶׁבָּנִתִּיו מֵעוֹדֶךָ.
תֵּדְעִי כִּי יוֹם תָּגוּדִי – אָסוֹנִי בְּגוּדֵךָ.
גַּם בְּעֵת יֶהֱרְסוּ עֵינַי לְהַבִּיט אֶל הוֹדֶךָ,
מִלְּחָיַיִךְ פֻּגְעוּ בִי נְחָשִׁים יַפְרִישׁוּ,
כִּי חֲמָתָם כָּאֵשׁ יַחְתּוּ, וְאוֹתִי יִגְרְשׁוּ.

שָׁלְלָה לִבִּי בַּדַּדִּים עֲלֵי לֵב מַגָּחִים:
לֵב כָּמוֹ אֶבֶן וְרַק יִגְמֹל שְׁנֵי תַפּוּחִים!
נִצָּבוּ וַיִּהְיוּ לִשְׂמֹאל וָיָמִין כִּרְמָחִים.
מוֹקְדֵיהֶם הֵם בְּלִבָּבִי – וְהֵם לֹא נִגְּשׁוּ,
גַּם בְּפִיהֶם דָּמִי שָׁתוּ – וְלֹא הִתְבּוֹשָׁשׁוּ!

יַעֲלָה חֹקֵי דַת הָאֵל בְּעֵינֶיהָ חָפֵר,
כִּי תְמִיתֵנִי בְּצִדִּיָּה אֲבָל אֵין לִי כֹּפֵר.
הֲרְאִיתֶם עוֹד לֵב אַרְיֵה וְצִפְעֹנִי עֹפֶר?
לָמְדוּ לִטְרֹף כַּלָּבִיא, וְחִצִּים יִלְטֹשׁוּ,
דַּם לְבָבִי יִמְצוּ יִשְׁתּוּ, וְנַפְשִׁי בִּקְּשׁוּ.

יוֹם אֲנִי מִיַּיִן דּוֹדֶיהָ כְּשִׁכּוֹר מִתְרוֹנֵן,
כִּי שְׁלוֹמֶיהָ תַּפְגִּיעַ וְעָלַי תִּתְלוֹנֵן
עַל יְדֵי צִירִים; וּכְבוֹאָם, אֲלֵיהֶם תִּתְחַנֵּן:
'מַלְאֲכֵי שָׁלוֹם, פֻּגְעוּ בִי, שְׁנוּ גַּם שְׁלִשׁוּ!'
מַאֲמָרָם לִבִּי פִּתּוּ וְרוּחִי חִדְּשׁוּ.

THE SENSITIVE DOE

O graceful doe, pity this heart in which you have dwelled all your life. Know that the day you leave me, your going will be my ruin. And even now, when my eyes dare to glance at your splendour, I am stung by the serpents that guard your cheeks, for their poison burns like fire and they drive me out.

She ensnared my heart with the breasts that lie upon her heart – a heart of stone, and yet it put forth two apples! They stand guard, to the left and to the right, like lances. Their fiery [nipples burn] in my heart, though they have never come near me. Their mouths have drunk my blood, they felt no shame at all!

This doe violates the laws of God with her eyes: she kills me with malice aforethought, yet no one avenges me. Have you ever seen the heart of a lion joined to the eyelids of a gazelle? Her eyelids have learned to tear like a lion, they hurl sharpened arrows at me, they drain my heart's blood to the dregs. They are out for my life.

One day, when I was reeling like a drunkard, longing for the wine of her love, she dispatched envoys to me bearing greetings and complaints; and when they returned to her, she begged them: 'O messengers of peace, come again and yet again!' These tidings seduced my heart and revived my spirit.

יום בְּגַנָּהּ רָעוּ יָדַי וְדָדֶיהָ עָשׂוּ,
אָמְרָה: 'הָרֶף יָדֶיךָ – הֲכִי עוֹד לֹא נָסוּ!'
וְאָמְרִים לִי הֶחֱלִיקָה לְבָבִי הַמַּסּוּ:
'גַּן מִתָּא נַקְשׁ, יָא חַבִּיבִי, פַּאנְכַר דְּנַאשוּ
אַלְגַּלְאַלָה רַכִּיצָה בְּשִׁתְאַת הַפַּרְמְשׁוּ.'

But one day when my hands were grazing in her garden and fondling her breasts, she said: 'Now take away your hands – they are not skilful enough.'[1] And her words were so seductive that they melted my heart: 'Do not touch me, friend, I do not like those who hurt me. My breasts are soft and sensitive. Enough! I shall refuse one and all!'[2]

עָפְרָה תְּכַבֵּס

THE LAUNDRESS

עָפְרָה תְּכַבֵּס אֶת בְּגָדֶיהָ בְּמֵי
דִמְעִי וְתִשְׁטְחֵם לְשֶׁמֶשׁ זָהֳרָהּ:
לֹא שָׁאֲלָה מֵי הָעֲיָנוֹת – עִם שְׁתֵּי
עֵינַי, וְלֹא שֶׁמֶשׁ – לִיפִי תָּאָרָהּ.

My love washes her clothes in the water of my tears and spreads them out in the sun of her beauty. She has no need of spring-water – she has my two eyes; nor of the sun – she has her own radiance.

מַה לָּךְ, צְבִיָּה

SONG OF FAREWELL

מַה לָּךְ, צְבִיָּה, תִּמְנָעִי צִירַיִךְ
מִדּוֹד, צָלְעָיו מָלְאוּ צִירַיִךְ?
לֹא תֵדְעִי כִּי אֵין לְדוֹדֵךְ מִזְּמַן
בִּלְתִּי שְׁמֹעַ קוֹל שְׁלוֹמוֹתַיִךְ?
אִם הַפְּרִידָה עַל שְׁגִינוּ נִגְזְרָה –
עִמְדִי מְעַט עַד אֶחֱזֶה פָנַיִךְ.
לֹא אֵדָעָה אִם בֵּין צְלָעַי נֶעֱצַר
לִבִּי, וְאִם יֵלֵךְ לְמַסָּעַיִךְ.

Why, O fair one, do you withhold your envoys from the lover whose heart is filled with pain of you? Do you not know that Time means nothing to your beloved, unless he hear your welcoming voice? If we two are doomed to parting, stay a while and let me look at your face. I do not know if my heart has come to a stop between my ribs, or else has wandered off with you. Oh,

1. Or, 'they [my breasts] have not yet experienced such things'.
2. The last two lines are in mixed Arabic and Romance. The meaning is uncertain.